



Setting Up Discussion Forums Using Vanilla

Use Vanilla Forums for work, to discuss ideas, or just to connect people across the organisation.

The need for, and the means of, communication between individuals of similar interests has existed since time immemorial. Discussion forums like Google Groups have scaled interaction to higher levels. Everyone benefits from an interaction. The people who contribute at some time are on the receiving side the rest of the time. This development of knowledge is what enables progress in science and technology.

Vanilla Forums (VF) is a discussion forum based on the LAMP stack, which can improve the levels of interaction and collaboration within your organisation.

Why another forum software?

There are many discussion forums on the Internet that employees already participate in. They could be officially representing the company in some, and sharing their personal views in others. Having a forum within the organisation (on the intranet) helps the company in many ways. Companies need a barrier to prevent confidential information from flowing outside. Also, the overexposure of employees on public forums or social networking sites could result in the company's image taking a beating. Further, a discussion

forum on the company intranet can complement real-time interactions. Most individuals are hard pressed for time at work and may lack opportunities to meet for discussions. Forum conversations can enable more people to join the discussion at a convenient time.

The greatest benefit of intranet discussion forums will be greater productivity. They help 'break the ice' and get like-minded people to form groups. Such collaboration, given the right direction, could lead to better ideas, a better workplace atmosphere, and also can act as effective bottom-to-top communication.

Hosting an intranet discussion group

While there are many discussion forum products available, Vanilla is ideal for informal interactions on the intranet. Its set-up and configuration are very simple. It has an easy registration process, and a good number of plug-ins that add features. The look-and-feel of the product is just right for people to 'hang out'. The default theme is simple and attractive enough to get started with conversations. Whether it involves pictures of the recent team outing, or speaking out against a petrol price hike,